China

The Chinese Empire has long fascinated historians and artists because of its rich culture. China is one of the largest countries in the world and considered to be the oldest civilization in world history. It takes its name from the Sanskrit word *Cina*, which in turn is derived from the Qin Dynasty. Although Qin Dynasty was the first imperial dynasty, it is referred to as the fourth dynasty after the Xia and Shang Dynasties. Both of the Greeks and the Romans called this empire “Seres”, which translates to “Where the Silk comes from”. This is because silk was transported frequently along the Silk Road from China to the West. The first recorded instance of the name “China” can be found within the journals of Barbosa that were written in 1516. Marco Polo, the renowned Venetian explorer, called this country “Cathay”. The Chinese people called their own country Zhongguo, which means “The Middle Kingdom”.

The history of China is divided into 19 legitimate dynasties with more than 100 so-called illegitimate dynasties. The Xia Dynasty is considered to have existed during the first period, which dated between 2,070 and 1,600 BCE. For a long time it was thought that the Xia Dynasty was a mere myth but recent excavations have revealed sites that prove the existence of this dynasty. Artifacts, bronze works, and burial sites show there was definitely a native civilization that lived during this time.

According to legend, it was Yu the Great who established the Xia Dynasty (2070 BC). Yu worked for 13 years to subdue the flow of the Yellow River. The river is known for constantly flooding the region and destroying the people’s crops. He would labor day and night to build dams for the people. Because of this, people began to praise him openly and eventually followed him. Shun was the ruler at the time who named Yu as his heir and continued to rule until he died. When Yu came to power, he founded a new systematic approach to appointing heirs. This idea led to the formation of what is known today as dynasties. The rulers and the elite classes lived in major urbanized centers while the peasants lived along the countryside.